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Rob Mounsey

Rob Mounsey has led a robust career as a keyboardist, session musician, arranger, and composer. He has collaborated with a lengthy list of the finest musicians in the business.

Rob was interviewed via Zoom on April 9, 2025 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. I'm very, very pleased to have Rob Mounsey today with me today, and I'm going to describe you — from my research papers that surround me — that you have to be one of the busiest guys in the music business.

RM: I don't know about that. I'm not that busy today, it's just you. Just you and me.

MR: That's, you know I had a question, so I'll ask it anyway, when we're done here, do you have an assignment that you need to get back to? A writing assignment?

RM: A couple things coming up but not pressing. It's still being discussed, yeah a production job and a few other things. Little arrangements.

MR: What kind of parameters go into the discussion? Is it budget, is it recording time?

RM: Yeah, sure. I mean budget is always an issue which I tend to leave to my manager and try to avoid talking about money. But yeah, it's schedule and what exactly is needed and how can I help supply what's needed and what's missing? What can I contribute, you know, what would someone like me to contribute? What do I feel I can? And are we on the same wavelength. I guess the older you get, the more years you put into it, you're more and more interested in working with people you enjoy working with and that's a big factor.

MR: It leads me to a question I had. In all your work, have you had instances where people want you to write horn parts or string sweetening and you get a track to listen to and it's so busy already that you just have to say there's no room here? Or do you figure out a way to contribute?

RM: That can happen. That can happen. I can't think of too many occasions where that happened. I mean usually if people want something to be, you know, added to that way there's usually room somewhere. Sometimes there isn't a lot of room. You know I lived through a whole era years ago where people wanted orchestrations on everything, say in the late '70s, early '80s, and big record companies and big producers felt like they just wanted to sound expensive. You know they wanted it to sound like they spent money on it, which is I guess probably not the best reason to be doing that. I'd rather it be done for

usually a way to add something. Sometimes there isn't a lot of room and what you add is kind of minimal.

MR: Have you ever been in a situation where you look at your score and you say, "You know they hired two bassoon players and I hardly have anything for them. I should give them something to play?

RM: Interesting you should choose the bassoon. I love the bassoon. I mean I love the bassoon in the orchestra, it's a wonderful instrument. I do a lot of orchestral pops arrangements for Cincinnati Pops, Boston Pops and other orchestras and for events where they accompany singers. And I love the orchestra madly, but I think it's very important when creating those things to give every single person a reason to be there. You know? And to put in front of that second bassoonist a part that that musician recognizes as a bassoon part. You know? This is a part for me, it makes me sound good, it makes me feel good, it lays nicely on the instrument, you know, displays an understanding of the registers of the instrument, and now I know why I missed all those baseball games as a kid because I had lessons and I was practicing. You know I had the highest highest respect for those orchestra musicians, especially the string players who were all my heroes. If you can play a violin or cello or viola and make it sound beautiful, I take my hat off to you. Because those instruments are so insanely hard to play. And they deserve to have parts that make sense for them and make them sound good and make them remember why they do this, because they love it and because they sound beautiful doing it. The pops orchestras, I'm getting away from your question a little bit because this is not so much about recording as about live performance but those pops orchestras have to confront a lot of really terrible arrangements.

MR: It sounds like you avoided the things that some of us have experienced, for instance your first time writing string parts and the concertmaster looks over his glasses and said, "Young man, the violin cannot play a low F sharp."

RM: That actually happened one time. And I was very embarrassed. But the only — I know, I know how a violin is tuned. The only reason it happened was because there was an arrangement and someone at the last minute demanded that it be transposed down a semi-tone. So we ended up with a G flat in the violins and David Nadien, the brilliant concertmaster for the Philharmonic and a great, great concertmaster in hundreds of sessions was laughing at me a little bit. He knew that I knew better. He said, "Rob, Rob, we are not violas. We cannot play this G flat." And of course I was humiliated. It was because there was a transposition and I didn't proofread it.

MR: And you probably resisted saying, "It's not my fault, I know better."

RM: It was my fault. I did know better and it was my fault, I should have proofread it and

ranges are. So yes. You know the pops orchestras, when they do special concerts accompanying pop singers and so forth, sometimes they'll bring in very poorly written arrangements that where it's the bass player in the band or something, he knows the chords and knows more or less what the registers of the instruments are. You know they see some really terrible arrangements.

MR: Go ahead. I'm going to take you back for a minute to, oh I'm going to say 1964. Were you listening to AM radio, pop music?

RM: You know at that time I was kind of a little classical music snob and I wasn't really — I thought I was just above all that pop music stuff. I was a skinny little music nerd with glasses and I was learning to — you know I had learned to read music by studying orchestra scores and when The Beatles broke on Ed Sullivan I just thought oh that stuff is not for me. But privately, you know, I was hearing "Meet The Beatles" over the backyard fence and thinking I kind of really like the way those guitars sound. And you know I kind of really like that John Lennon singing that's so vinegary and thin and like it kind of sounds good. I like the way the cymbals sound on the drum kit. It's kind of cool but I wouldn't admit it at the time. And later on there was Stevie Wonder and Miles Davis, John Coltrane and then it just started opening up.

MR: I'm wondering if there was — you made me think of George Martin, and did you take note?

RM: My favorite Beatle.

MR: Your favorite Beatle. Yes indeed.

RM: Yeah.

MR: And these things entered your mind, like I remember listening to Little Eva, Carole King and the "Locomotion" —

RM: Yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: And then going, "What is that sound?" And I think it was like two tenor saxes playing in fifths [blurts a note] or something. They go in here and later on you use that for something.

RM: Yeah, yeah. Steal from the best.

MR: Steal from the best.

RM: Yeah.

MR: Has your work changed? I'm leapfrogging but I remember talking to a fellow at Eastman named Dave Rivello. I went to his house and in his music room he's got big score pads. Yellow King score pads. He insists on writing in pencil.

RM: Yeah.

MR: And do you miss those days or how has it affected the way you work?

RM: I do miss them a lot. Excuse me one second. I just happen to have some right here. Sturdy staff paper. Yes. The process has changed and I'm not real happy about it. It used to be always pencil and paper, finish it, fold it in half, put the title and the date on it, and send it away to somebody, to a copyist who would then write the parts out by hand. Definitely come from that old school. And nowadays I type stuff into Sibelius because people want, they just want me to deliver PDFs. So I deliver PDFs of scores and parts. Since I have to type everything into the score I can't make myself write it out long hand in pencil anymore so for big orchestra things I generally make a six staff sketch, which is, you know, double staff woodwinds, brass and strings, and whatever other little notes I put in there. You know, sketch everything out because the most important thing is to have all of the bars, all the bar numbers, all the rehearsal letters, you know, any extra double bars to demarcate phrases between rehearsal letters, and — but you know I'm sketching out all the ideas, a lot of the voicings, especially the counterpoint, because the counterpoint's really, really important to me. And that has to really be worked out so it really works. So that's all in the sketch and then I type into Sibelius and I work out most of the little details as I'm typing it in, and throw the sketch away.

MR: No, no. You have to save it.

RM: I'm sorry, they're gone. The sketches are gone, I have all the files, you know I have all the Sibelius files and the PDFs, so there's no information lost. You know I can't make myself believe that the sketches are going to be in the Smithsonian someday, like they're gonna be, someone's gonna care. I really doubt it.

MR: Well that's arguable but do your scores have an architectural look to them?

RM: Well I think any good score does. In my opinion. And it's funny you should say that because when I was a kid that was one of the big motivators for me. I encountered orchestra scores and little Kalmus miniature orchestra scores, those little green books. And I was just so attracted to the way they look. I love the way they look. Like because as you say, they kind of look like architectural drawings or these beautiful blueprints. And it's like a code. I know that it's a written code for a musical experience, which is a completely different experience and I was just so fascinated with how they look and I remember feeling like I want to learn how to make these. I think I can make these you know.

MR: And you did at age 17 is that right? I see you got a — let's see — BMI Student Composer Award.

RM: Yeah. That was quite a moment.

MR: I'll bet.

RM: I flew to New York City for the first time and there was a little — I was just in a daze but

lot of very famous contemporary serious composers, concert composers, who I barely appreciated and I was already interested in jazz music and in all kinds of popular music. But yeah, I had been writing this crazy orchestra music from age eleven or so at that point.

MR: Can you define crazy for me?

RM: Well it was very, very — well it was juvenilia. I mean it was pretty bad. But it was very imaginative and very far out, and very experimental. Experiments of all — experiments of all kinds. Experiments in polyrhythm, polytonality, and crazy orchestration. And I was, you know I was just learning by having fun with it, and studying any other scores I could get my hands on.

MR: I don't know if you can answer this, but this of course, when you're 17, this is pre-Sibelius etcetera, so you're writing this score, how much of it can you actually hear in your head?

RM: It's kind of hard to define. I mean generally yes, I can hear it in my head. But not really in detail you know. It's not the same. It's not the same. I remember being a child and hearing very vividly music, hearing it mentally, as if it were playing in the room. I think that that ability of the brain kind of lessens as you get older. It was — but I never heard any of that music. I still have that score actually, it's close by, that won that award in 1970 I think it was.

MR: Were you surprised when you — maybe surprised isn't the right word. What was your reaction when you first heard it played by the orchestra?

RM: I never heard it played. I've never heard it played. It's never been played. Would you like to play it? You can put the orchestra together, it's really pretty far out. It's never been played.

MR: How — I'm a little confused, I thought that if you had got a composer award that some orchestra would have played it.

RM: No.

MR: Well that's —

RM: The board, the composers read the score and said, "We'll give this kid a prize." I was the second youngest that year. It's for anyone in the Western Hemisphere up to age 35, and I was 17. There was one guy younger than me, he was 15, and he won the prize for a piano piece called "Advice from a Caterpillar" which I thought was one of the greatest titles I've ever heard. I loved it at the time, not that I heard the piece, but I loved the title.

MR: Well you might have just answered my last question — so I'm going to go there. If you had an unlimited budget and the time to pursue it, what would be your dream project? So maybe you'd want to hear that piece played.

RM: I don't know. Maybe. Maybe. Maybe. You're putting an idea in my head again which is that I could, you know, electronic production is sophisticated enough now that I could make a pretty good mock-up of it. And I hadn't thought about trying to do that. But that would be interesting.

MR: Well I think you should start that about 3:00 this afternoon.

RM: Okay. After nap. At this point, yeah. You need a nap first.

MR: Well you weren't into pop music in 1964 but you got there. I'm wondering about, as a keyboardist, were you required or felt you were required to keep up with keyboard technology in order to keep working?

RM: Yes. Well it might not have had to have been but I was very interested. And I jumped on that little bus pretty early. The first synthesizer that I ever bought was an ARP 2600 with the patch cords, rainbow patch cords. And that was in 1977. I was just interested in whatever the possibilities turned out to be. And for a while in the early '80s I became — you know I was working a lot as a studio musician, from the time I was about 24, 25. So I became one of those synth guys. I had, you know —

MR: Did you have a DX-7?

RM: I had two DX-7s, I had a Prophet-5, a Roland Jupiter 8, I had an old Oberheim 4-voice, which was a kind of big kluge of an instrument. And then I had a whole lot of other outboard modular stuff that I could patch into. And you know about five or six road cases, and I became one of those guys where cartage guys would schlep in all these cases for a day and you'd set up in the control room and do synthesizer overdubs for a day on people's pop records and productions.

MR: Did you take them without really knowing if you were going to use them?

RM: Sure.

MR: So a producer might say —

RM: You'd take everything.

MR: We need this kind of sound [hums] that's what we want and it's like your job is to make them happy.

RM: Yeah. Yeah. You just take everything, set everything up, and you might end up like just making a couple little [hums], you know just a couple little noises and that was the day. But you know in those days you could watch people throw untold scads of money at pop records, and people were making money making records and they were used to spending that. You know those days ended with a crash.

MR: About when?

RM: Late '80s I'd say. It just, people realized it wasn't necessary anymore.

MR: And did you then make a concerted effort to redirect your talents to wherever the money

RM: I was never motivated by money. I have to admit, yes, to the occasional disapproval of some family members I just wasn't motivated by money. The synth thing went a little bit out of style but also the technology meant that all of that analog equipment kind of became replaced by digital plug-ins, and now I have a set-up which is quite small and simple with loads of software. So that technology changed a lot. And if people want me to overdub sounds on their production they can just email files to me, I'll do it in my own little place and send them back. And that happens pretty often. I know a lot of studio musicians that, especially guitarists for some reason, they become very adept at home recording. And guitarists, you know they have not only 17 different guitars but also every kind of guitar-like instrument, the ukuleles and the Mexican cuatros and the baglama saz and the Brazilian, you know

MR: Charangas or something like that.

RM: Cavaquinhos and the different banjos, the tenor banjo, the five string banjo, the pedal steel. And so they collect the microphones and the pre-amps and they can do everything at home now and a lot of playing musicians are very, very adept at all of that and they can do great work at home.

MR: I know Randy Brecker mentioned that, things in the mail and overdubbed solos.

RM: Yeah he does quite a lot of that. I've done that with him with my buddy Steve Khan, guitarist. Steve and Randy are close and I know Randy well. Steve is a buddy of mine. And Bob Mintzer I think is another one.

MR: Can you recall a studio date, a keyboard date where you came in and said to yourself, "Wow I'm not — this is going to be a real challenge for me" for one reason or another?

RM: Yeah. Well my favorite story about that is the Steely Dan track called "Glamour Profession" where I played a piano solo. This is the only time that I was ever a soloist for them.

[absent keyboard sound]

I don't know Steely Dan fanatics know this, this is a famous thing. And you're not one of them I sense. But anyway —

MR: Well I am except that what you played I couldn't hear because the Zoom —

RM: Oh because Zoom cut it out.

MR: Yes Zoom doesn't really like it, but yes I'm a huge Steely Dan fan, yeah.

RM: Well there's a piano solo and they called me in to play the piano solo. This was Automated Beat in New York. It must have been 1982 I think. And you know they were famously, famously very, very exacting which nobody ever minded because everybody loved the music and loved the songs. And we got the piano solo in a couple of hours, maybe two hours, which is pretty good for them. Two punches, it's 12 bars, we carefully

just play, comp a little bit through the rest of the track because we don't want the piano to just appear out of nowhere, we want it to kind of be part of the band so just —." Okay that didn't sound too difficult so they played the track and the song, if you remember it, is very harmonically strange. It's very harmonically unsettled. It's sort of constantly making left turns.

MR: That's a great word for it, I've never been able to pin down how that song makes me feel and you just did it. Unsettled.

RM: Yeah. It's harmonically, harmonically it sort of doesn't come to rest. Where you think it's coming to rest and then it jumps off and goes somewhere else. And so that was strange. But I mean if you're just reading chord symbols and just kind of comping that shouldn't be a problem. And yet they rolled the track and I tried to just you know play a rhythm comping part in whatever way felt natural at the time. I couldn't find it because the track sounded so complete. I might have been the very last thing to be added to it. And the track sounded really finished and it felt finished and I couldn't, whatever I played rhythmically, everybody was basically rhythmically playing a one-bar pattern. Not two or four, one. And whenever I played I felt like I was stepping on somebody else. So I had to go into the booth and say let me just really listen to the track and I had to try to listen really analytically. Like who's playing what? Who's playing on what beats of the bar? And what I came up with was nobody was really playing right on beat three except the kick drum, and there's a very simple drum pattern. It's got a [scats] like a, just quarter notes. But aside from the kick drum nobody was really playing right on beat three. So I went back out in the room and tried just playing on beat three for a minute, and ended up feeling like three-and. It goes one, two, three-and; one, two, three-and, and that started to feel strange but it started to feel good actually. So if you listen to that track now you'll hear a lot of the track is the piano will just sort of play two eighth notes on the third beat. And it's weird but it kind of worked and it sort of added to the personality of the song. You know it added to this kind of little bit like reggae-disco feeling of the song. And then there are a few other little things, a couple little decorations here and there. So that was a challenge and it wasn't a challenge because it was difficult in any technical way, it was a challenge to figure out what would work.

MR: Hm. Figuring out what would work. This — when I read your credits on here it says that you collaborated with Donald Fagen on the horn parts.

RM: Um hum.

MR: So I'm trying to imagine how that works. Do you sit and listen to the track and you both trade turns like humming something — or here's a spot let's put something in here?

RM: What it mostly meant was he'd play it for me and sometimes he would actually dictate

know. For instance in the song "IGY" I think that's the opening song [scats] in B. If I turn this up –

MR: Yeah I can sort of hear that.

RM: Oh okay. That's all Donald. That's Donald's thing. But then it goes from B major, as it goes into the verse it has to pivot into F minor, an extremely remote modulation from five sharps to four flats. And he didn't know how to get out of that line. So I figured out [scats]. That was me. You know pivot on the G sharp note, make in an A flat and then put a G natural next to it and then you're indicating F minor, four flats. But that was the kind of weird stuff that was not that natural to him. And he used to say to me, "You know I could do this, I don't really need you to do this except it would take me three months and it takes you half an hour. And he was right, he could have done it himself but I was faster. To me it was sort of like at the center of how I heard stuff and saw it, and for him he was writing all those great songs.

MR: Well you've solved two of my Steely Dan personal questions already today. Thank you. Were you in the ad game for a while?

RM: Well yeah. We all were. You know all the studio musicians generally made money by playing on TV commercials and radio commercials and that was a huge business in the end of the '70s and the early '80s, especially if you could write the stuff and arrange it and if you could pass as a background singer and sing on them. That was the way people made real money in those days.

MR: Yeah. I just did an interview with Anne Phillips and she talked about that. Did you ever work with the ad person and — I remember Mike Abene mentioned something about trying to do a commercial and the representative from the ad agency is saying, "Can't you make it more yellow?" And have you had circumstances like that where you've got to figure out what are they talking about?

RM: Oh yeah. Oh yeah. There are a lot of funny stories about ad people who are sort of drunk with power and how much money they're spending on you, and believe that they understand music and they don't. There are lots of those stories. The weirdest one that ever happened to me was there's a 30-second commercial where there's supposed to be a big lift about 10 seconds into the 30 seconds, and so we made a piece that makes a really nice bright modulation, a key modulation. It gets bigger, the low end goes down, the high end goes up and it modulates in a bright direction. And it was working great. And the ad people are saying, "I love that part, I love that part where that happens." And we're saying, "Yeah it works really well." And they say, "Can you make that happen at the beginning?" "No." "Why not?" It's hard to explain but the reason it works is because of what came before it. And if nothing comes before it it won't be there. Like you think it

you're just a musician. Why should they listen to you? I mean they're the people wearing the suits and the ties.

MR: Yeah. As a producer yourself, sometimes I wonder if you have trouble zipping your mouth in a session because like you know that something should be done differently but it's not your role to say that?

RM: Well if I'm producing a record it is my role to say that. I mean it's like being the director of a movie. If I'm the producer and I think —

MR: But if you're not –-

RM: Yeah. Yeah. Well you know there are all kinds of producers. There's no licensing for that job. So some are really very, very knowledgeable, competent and know what they want; and many others are, you know, famously — the jokes about record producers are that they don't know what they want and they're just kind of flailing and hoping something happens. You know?

MR: Because they'll take credit for it.

RM: Well sure. "How many record producers does it take to change a light bulb?" "I don't know, what do you think" is the joke.

MR: Okay.

RM: But they're not all like that and I have to say my friend Russ Titelman is not whatsoever like that. I've done a lot of stuff with him, you're familiar with that name maybe.

MR: Indeed.

RM: He's an old friend of mine and he's the only guy who could ever do something like I was playing a chord as a synthesizer overdub, and it was a little bit of a thick sort of jazz-adjacent kind of chord with a lot of notes in it. And he walked up to my left ear and he said, "What's that note [hums a pitch]." He very softly sings a note [hums] and yes it is in the chord I'm playing. And I say, "Oh that's the G natural, it's the — it's actually the 13th. He says, "We don't need that note." And he was right. And I didn't play that note. He was exactly right. We didn't need that — and I was pretty impressed by that. But he was a musician. He doesn't really play now I think but that he should hear a note in the chord and tell me to take out the most sophisticated note because it wasn't appropriate. I don't know anyone else that could do that actually.

MR: I'm always amused by when studio musicians forget that they've played on a particular recording and you point it out to them. Like Bucky Pizzarelli for instance, you know, hundreds of things. And I saw John tell him once like, "You played on that, Dad." And he goes — so I'm going to see if you can remember one of your own tunes. Okay? But the way I'm going to do this is I'm going to see if you can recognize it from this?

RM: Okay hold on I need [scats]. It's very familiar.

RM: Oh yeah.

MR: And the name of it is?

RM: "Miss Downtown."

MR: That is right. You get to move on to the next round.

RM: That was — wow, how'd you find that thing? That's was an attempt to write the theme song for "Sex and the City."

MR: Which you did later.

RM: No. Well I did a lot of kind of — I contributed a lot of scoring music to it but they were looking for a theme and that was my submission for the theme, which lost. I think it deserved to win. I still think it deserved to win.

MR: I agree 'cause it stuck in my head all the way home in the car from my office [scats]. It was fun to transcribe. I only did the first eight bars, but I wonder, it made me think, do you have a personal — I'll call it a pass/fail metric for your own tunes? Work on something and is it — there's some level that it has to pass for it to remain a work for you.

RM: Well I can't say that there's one particular standard or level. I guess I feel like you're always making a lot of small choices when you make any musical piece you're making hundreds of choices and you just kind of make them inch by inch.

MR: I think the reason I ask that is because I listened to a number of the selections from "Hallucination Box" and they're all hooky.

RM: Thank you I think. No I think I know —

MR: Hooks are good. Sometimes multiple hooks. If you think of songs you remember as a kid you know like "My Girl." "My Girl's" got like one hook after another.

RM: Yes. Right. Yeah. Well some of those were attempts to make some little scoring pieces, and some of them were just for fun that's why a lot of them are very short, they're just kind of little fun experiments.

MR: Do you have an opinion about the way music is delivered to listeners now?

RM: Sure. I mean it's, you know it's horrendous how much creative — how little creative people are paid for streaming. It's virtually nothing. And it's, you know it's a terrible problem but this has been a terrible problem for years that we used to sell physical units of stuff and now we don't. And trying to persuade people to buy some physical product is really difficult when you can pretty much hear everything streaming somewhere. So you know I mean the problem is much bigger than you and me and I have no — I don't have any solutions.

MR: Well to be specific, why are the songs from "Hallucination Box" readily available on YouTube? Did you do that?

RM: No. I didn't do that. But I do get Internet royalties which have been going up a little bit, as modest as they are. So I can't speak very intelligently about any business issues. I'm not good at it. I think I have a fair knack for putting one note next to another note, and I'm still doing that. That's about as far as it goes. I defer to wiser heads when it comes to the business stuff. I don't understand it all that well. I do have a digital distributor that makes sure that those albums are available on Apple Music and what used to be iTunes and so forth.

MR: Okay. Was there a moment early on when some of these — have you mostly worked in New York? Is that correct?

RM: Mostly but also in L.A. and Nashville.

MR: Were you familiar with some of the players like Bucky and Joe Wilder and — those guys from an earlier generation and go to a session where you arranged the music and there they are. And what did that feel like?

RM: Great. It felt great. Joe Wilder I don't know. I worked with Bucky exactly once and that was on a record Lyle Lovett's remake of "The Summer Wind" produced by Russ Titelman again, and Bucky plays his — you know it's sort of like a small big band and a live string section of all things, of only violins and violas. A small — it was supposed to kind of sound like a big band but it's only about seven horns. And Bucky was just great. A great guy. But I think if you look up that record, Lyle Lovett, "Summer Wind" you'll hear his quarter note rhythm guitar featured a lot and it's so, you know, the rhythmic pocket is just so wonderful. And I wish I had known him better. I know John. I haven't seen John in a while but I know him. Father and son are fabulous.

MR: Do you have a, I'll call it a backlog of available things you've written if some opportunity comes up, someone needs a theme?

RM: Yeah.

MR: And you can go through your work and say, "Hmm, this might be perfect."

RM: Yeah. Yeah. I have some stuff like that. Thanks for reminding me I should keep up with it.

MR: How do you organize it?

RM: It's in a folder on my desktop. You know, and once in a great while I have made contact with some music supervisor or something and I say you know, "I have some tracks that could be licensable" and, "Oh that's nice, send them." And I send them and then I never hear from them again and that's how that goes. I mean in theory they could use the stuff and never tell me. I don't know. I don't think they would do that but you never know.

MR: This is a timely question I think with the way the business is going, but when I look at your list of credits and all the things you've done, is there a sound that people know you

describing a Steely Dan thing and you had like two bass clarinets and an alto flute and — is there a "Rob sound" that people remember you for? That's part one of this question.

RM: I don't think so. Not to my knowledge. I don't think there is and I kind of hope not because you know it was always really important to me to be versatile. By the way, the two bass clarinets and the alto flute, I think those were Donald Fagen's ideas anyway. You know I've had, maybe you've seen some other interviews where people will sometimes say, "You seem to be so versatile, you know, I admire that." And I thought about it a lot, I realized that the versatility insofar as I've achieved it, you know it really came from fear. It came from terror. Because I knew when I was in school and got out of school, I really wanted to do music and make a living at it somehow. And I had real doubts as — you know I think it's reasonable to wonder can you make a living at it. I think it's more difficult now than it was then, but I remember — and I think the strategy I kind of evolved was I better be as versatile as possible and be able to go to this genre and this style, and be able to live over here and live over here and you know it needed to be convincing that I can live there and I belong there and understand the conventions of that style and the literature, the history of it so that versatility kind of came from — I wanted to make sure I could make a living doing it. So do I have a sound that people associate with me I don't know. I don't know.

MR: I think it's an excellent answer because if people do associate you specifically with something they may not call you because that's not what they want.

RM: Yeah. And people often typecast you know, and for certain people I'm like the guy who does string arrangements. And for other people I'm the guy who does horn arrangements. And they don't know that I'd ever do string arrangements. They say, "Oh you do string arrangements too?" Like that's a different thing. You know it's not a different thing, musical arranging is arranging. And I suppose there might be some people that really specialize in one thing or the other but that doesn't make sense to me.

MR: Do you get arranging ideas away from the keyboard or even away from when you're working. I guess I'm thinking of you've got some assignment and you've got the track in your head and you go for a walk and something comes to you. Oh there it is, I can do that.

RM: Yes, sure. Yeah. Did you know that the human brain works better when you're standing than when you're sitting?

MR: I did not.

RM: That's what some scientists —

MR: I've got to stand more then.

RM: Yeah me too. And the other corollary of that is it works better when you're walking than

have a feeling that we want to pace around when we're thinking, because the brain actually works better. So yeah, going for a walk and looking at a tree can be a great way to refresh your — refresh yourself, your ability to imagine and think and feel. And as I like to say, you know I speak to students once in a while and I like to say music really comes from the whole body and it comes from the whole person. It's not something that's just in your head. You know? If you're sitting at a piano and staring at the staff you're only in one little part of it — which can be a great part, and a really interesting part, kind of to play with little sparkling cerebral ideas, but we all know that it's about a lot more than that. It's about your feelings, your emotions, and also the way that your body moves and the rhythmic feelings in your body. You know if I'm writing a horn arrangement or something, you know I've done a lot of stuff — write funky little horn arrangements for R&B records. And I really like to stand up and kind of pretend that I'm playing a tenor saxophone, which I don't really play. I play a little bit. But just to stand up and kind of dance around and just listen to the track and just go like this. Because you know it loosens up a natural feeling for what belongs there. Something that you don't really get when you're just sitting there thinking about it.

MR: Oh that makes so much sense. As a saxophone player I just, you know [scats] you've got that physical part of the playing.

RM: Yes. It feels a certain way and you can feel it down in the soles of your feet where they hit the floor you know, and that's — if you're connected with that that reaches people.

MR: Do you do any kind of meditation or sort of downtime to focus yourself?

RM: I'm glad you asked that because it's — you're encouraging me to do it more. I need to do it more. You know I have a great interest in Zen Buddhism and you know I've done a fair amount of that, but I'm a lazy kind of practitioner, I'm just very undisciplined. But I have a great interest in that. And you know to a certain extent everything that you do can be meditation in a sense.

MR: This is a tough question but are you an optimist about the state of the state? The state of the nation?

RM: I'm extremely alarmed. I can't say I'm optimistic right now except to say that all things come to an end, even awful things like some stuff that's going on right now. Nobody lives forever.

MR: That's optimistic then. We'll go with that.

RM: Okay. Well that's the most optimistic thing I can say.

MR: Okay so you have a friend who has a son or daughter who wants to do what you do, and they're 16. Do you have any specific advice for them?

RM: That's so difficult. That is so difficult because it really has changed a lot. You know

people. [Sorry I've got the sun in my face.] And the business is so radically different now that I'm not sure that my — I always doubt that my own experiences are even appropriate anymore. The last time I saw Quincy Jones he actually sort of asked me this, he said, "How do you think young people get started today in this business?" And I had to say I have no idea. And he didn't either. Because it's radically different. Once a year I talk to students at NYU. We have an event every year about putting string sections on productions, on pop songs. [I'm trying to adjust my lighting, sorry.]

MR: Sure.

RM: And some students are saying, "Well I'm a singer/songwriter and a performer and I really want to have hit records and make a lot of money." And I have to say, "If you're really motivated by money go into another line of work. If money motivates you be a banker or something and do music on the side. You can always do music. You don't have to do it professionally." But it's too undependable. It's too much of a gamble I think. People that do music full time as a profession, they just, I think they just do it 'cause they really have to. You know? That's just who they are, they have to do it, they have to do it, they have to do it, they have to do it. And they're not — they're just not going to stop. It's like singers. You can always tell a singer, a real singer, because they just keep singing, they will not shut up. You can't stop them. They're always singing. And that's because they just have to. Or dancers, or actors. You know if you are really driven to do it you'll do it. There's no question that it's difficult to figure out how you're going to make a living from it and the scene is always changing. There might be ways to make a living at it next year that we don't know about now. There are probably ways to make a living at it today that you and I don't know about but some young people do. You know?

MR: Yeah some of them are writing tunes for videogames. I guess that's not new but it's one outlet.

RM: Yes. Yes. And increasingly viable, lucrative. So yeah. I don't understand much about that either. If someone called me to do it I'd give it a shot.

MR: To wrap up can you — we got a glimpse of a couple of gold records on your wall. You want to tell us about that?

RM: Oh they just happened to be over the piano. One is a triple platinum for Paul Simon "Graceland," and the other one is for Steely Dan "Gaucho." There's some more over there back there — "Graceland" harbors my —maybe my most heard horn arrangement of all time, which is the two-bar horn arrangement on "You Can Call Me Al" [scats] which millions and millions and millions of people have heard.

MR: Oh my.

RM: Yeah. It probably took five minutes to write it, and they left the credit off the album.

MR: Oh.

RM: Yeah so I was kind of, like a little bugged about that.

MR: How did that happen? You were listening to the track and it just like, you're humming to yourself? I mean can you describe that?

RM: Paul and Roy Halee asked me. I was in the studio with them and they asked me, "Can you make a brass section play this figure that the rhythm guitar is playing." It was of the African rhythm guitarists. I'm sorry I don't remember his name.

MR: Ray Phiri?

RM: Ray Phiri, maybe. Or there's another guy's name starts with a V. And it was just a rhythm guitar part. They said, "Can you make a brass section play that and by the way we really want to have a bass saxophone on the bottom, a B flat bass saxophone. I said sure.

MR: Howard Johnson.

RM: No I don't think so. I think it was Ronnie Cuber actually.

MR: Oh. But the bass saxophone didn't come in 'til later. Is that correct?

RM: No I think it's in the whole way, unless they took it out of the mix.

MR: Well all right.

RM: And it's two bars over and over except for the one time it's different.

MR: [scats]

RM: Yeah. [scats] that one time. So we're madly counting, "36, 37, here it comes." And you know it was very quick and very easy but I was so excited. I finally did an arrangement for a Paul Simon record. I was a huge Paul Simon fan, and they left the credit off the album. But it's okay. People know now that I did it for them.

MR: I'm going to tell all my friends too.

RM: Well Roy Halee made a big point of announcing that so —

MR: I love the fact that it starts with a rest.

RM: Yeah. Right. One [scats]. Yes it's rests on the downbeats of both bars. Yeah. But it's just what the rhythm guitarist played. Like give it to three trumpets and three trombones and a bass saxophone and make the registers work nice. I think actually toward the end somewhere it jumps up one inversion.

MR: Yes, I believe it does. Did you crack up with the video of that song with Chevy Chase?

RM: No. Not really. It was okay.

MR: Well thank you very much for your time today, Rob, this has just been very intriguing.

RM: Thank you, thanks, that's nice of you to say that. It's been fun for me, thanks for having me.

MR: All right. I'll just pause here and we'll say good-bye.